

the next set of destinations that highlight the country's hidden treasures, we will not only unlock the cultural tapestry of our nation, but also invigorate local economies. The benchmark set by global destinations like Singapore and Switzerland offer valuable insights. The seamless integration of technology in Singapore's tourism infrastructure and Switzerland's emphasis on preserving its natural beauty are beacons we could learn from.

Beyond the journey lies the in-destination experience, a critical facet that shapes any travel memory. Our investment in infra-structural development within a 20-30 km radius of tourism hotbeds should come through in ways that are more than just enhancement of facilities. It is a commitment to providing holistic and immersive experiences. Take Shimla or Manali for example; while there is a need to constantly innovate on capacity expansion in a sustained manner in a city like Shimla, a growing influx of tourists to the city helped rejuvenate 10 additional destinations around it. The key is to further develop these 'nearby' destinations for a better experience. In cities like Udaipur, known for its cultural richness, the development of alternative accommodations, including heritage homestays, has not only elevated the visitor experience, but also contributed to the preservation of local heritage. Such examples further bolster the case for a focussed approach to supporting homestays

at major tourism destinations and also as a great option for remote, smaller destinations to help fill an important gap in the tourism megastructure without large investments and at a low carbon footprint. Innovative models like eco-friendly resorts in the vicinity of ecologically sensitive areas such as the Western Ghats, Andamans, or the now much talked about Lakshadweep islands must also be

pilgrimage spots even for historical significance. This paradigm shift is a testament to the evolving dynamics of pilgrimage tourism, emphasising the need to develop destinations for significantly enhanced on-ground experience.

In a world where data is the new currency, our industry can use data-driven decision-making to shape the future of travel. We need to cover more ground to

unify our sector's data collection and analysis framework to not only inform our current strategies but also position us to anticipate and adapt to future trends. The way I see it, we are at the cusp of a renaissance of sorts as an industry; all on a journey to explore, experience, and elevate the incredible destinations that our country has to offer.

And while on the subject, sustainability can no longer be a mere checkbox

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looked at. These initiatives not only enhance the traveller's experience but also contribute to the conservation of delicate ecosystems. A shifting consumer profile prompts us to also reassess pilgrimages. Recognising the evolving spiritual seeker, who is in it for the 'tirth' (pilgrimage) and 'swaasth' (wellness), we have a huge opportunity in the form of embracing this new emerging trend where the Indian traveller is looking to explore

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ILLUSTRATION BY ANIRBAN GHOSH

